



Module 9 Lecture - Lifespan Development

Introductory Psychology

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Table of Contents

1	Overview and Introduction	2
1.1	Textbook Learning Objectives	2
1.2	Instructor Learning Objectives	2
1.3	Introduction	2
2	What is Lifespan Development?	3
2.1	Introduction	3
2.2	Different Areas of Development	3
2.3	The Normative Approach to Developmental Psychology	4
2.4	Nuances in Developmental Psychology	5
2.4.1	Continuous or Discontinuous?	5
2.4.2	One Course or Many?	6
2.4.3	Nature or Nurture (or Both)?	6
3	Lifespan Theories	7
3.1	Psychosexual Theory of Development (Frued)	7
3.2	Psychosocial Theory of Development (Erikson)	8
3.3	Cognitive Theory of Development (Piaget)	10
3.4	Moral Theory of Development (Kohlberg)	11
4	Conclusion	12
4.1	Recap	12
	Key Terms	13

1 Overview and Introduction

1.1 Textbook Learning Objectives

- Define and distinguish between the three domains of development: physical, cognitive and psychosocial
- Discuss the normative approach to development
- Understand the three major issues in development: continuity and discontinuity, one common course of development or many unique courses of development, and nature versus nurture
- Discuss Freud's theory of psychosexual development
- Describe the major tasks of child and adult psychosocial development according to Erikson
- Discuss Piaget's view of cognitive development and apply the stages to understanding childhood cognition
- Describe Kohlberg's theory of moral development
- Compare and contrast the strengths and weaknesses of major developmental theories

1.2 Instructor Learning Objectives

- Be able to identify key characteristics and ideas from the different developmental theories
- Be able to connect the different theorists to their views and perspectives
- Be able to apply the different developmental stages, given a specific age in an example

1.3 Introduction

- In this module, we will focus on the different perspectives of _____ of humans
 - There have been _____ different theories and ideas that describe how and why we develop, and it's important you can identify which people proposed which ideas

! Important

Much like with other theories we have discussed, there is not one fully 'correct' option; we should understand these different theories as offering different, and at times, complimentary information on our development.

2 What is Lifespan Development?

2.1 Introduction

- While **developmental psychologists** are often associated with research on _____, many actually research across the _____
- What is the **lifespan**?
 - It contains every stage of life, from conception to death
 - Across each of these stages, we look at three areas:
 - * _____ development
 - * _____ development
 - * _____ development

 Discuss: If we are in a psychology class, why would we care about physical development?

2.2 Different Areas of Development

- The focus of **physical development** is on the _____ and physiological changes to the body
 - E.g., changing hormones during puberty, developing control over speech muscles
- On the other hand, **cognitive development** focuses on things that we covered in module 7: like how we solve _____
 - E.g., development of better concentration, and faster processing speed
- Finally, **psychosocial development** is all about how people _____ with one another and how we portray our personality and emotions
 - E.g., developing inhibition against anger and sadness, like less tantrums (ideally)

 Discuss: What is *one* way that you have developed as a person from middle school to college? I.e., describe one of your characters arcs. Which of the above areas would this fall under?

2.3 The Normative Approach to Developmental Psychology

- Much of developmental psychology is interested in what is the _____ or the “usual” healthy course of development, especially _____ in life
 - This is still a focus today, but many _____ stay away from describing children or development as “normal” or “abnormal”
 - This approach to research is called the **normative approach**

Important

Many terms that started as scientific have been used as insults, e.g., ‘retarded’ just means ‘slow’, but has been used harmfully against many children. Be mindful of how clinical terms may be stigmatizing.

- Having some sense of _____ development can be useful in defining **developmental milestones**, _____ stages in our development
 - E.g., Crawling, Walking, first words, speaking and sentences
- While more _____ milestones, like puberty, tend to be _____ and occur at roughly the same time across different cultures, _____ milestones may be vastly different in different populations
 - E.g., First formal schooling may be very different in different countries

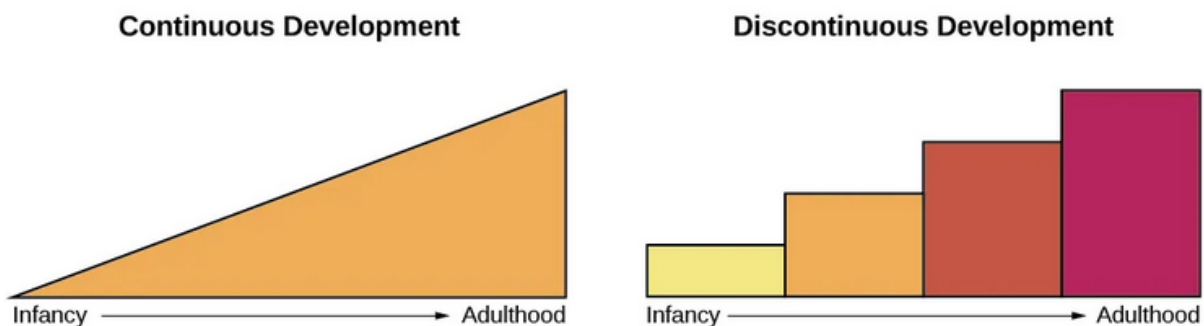
 Discuss: Why might a normative approach to developmental psychology might be anxiety inducing in a parent of a young child?

2.4 Nuances in Developmental Psychology

- As we work through the following _____ and researchers, keep in mind these several differences in how development is viewed:

2.4.1 Continuous or Discontinuous?

- The view of **continuous development** is that development is a _____ and gradually increasing slope
 - E.g., Slowly increasing height, weight throughout childhood
- Alternatively, **discontinuous development** is that which is organized into _____ stages
 - E.g., Pre-walking to Post-walking



? I am looking at the timing of when a child first becomes capable of recognizing themselves in the mirror, and from this point on, they now recognize themselves in reflection - is this better showing continuous or discontinuous development?

- ☒ A) Continuous
☐ B) Discontinuous
☐ C) Neither
☐ D) Both

Explanation:

! Important

You don't necessarily need to believe development is entirely continuous or entirely discontinuous! Maybe different components progress differently...

2.4.2 One Course or Many?

- Does our development course _____ based upon our culture, society, and environment? Or it is generally _____ regardless of our culture?

 Discuss: If we do differ across cultures, how might this make the normative approach to development more complicated?

2.4.3 Nature or Nurture (or Both)?

 Discuss: During what previous topic did we talk about nature and nurture (very briefly!)

- Our **nature** is our _____, built-in characteristics
 - E.g., our skin tone, our potential height, our facial structure
- But with **nurture**, we have how our _____ shapes our development
 - E.g., whether we are raised in a certain religion, certain political beliefs, certain ethical beliefs

Important

Like with pretty much everything we talk about in psychology - it's complicated - rarely is any part of how we think, act, and behave purely ascribable to our nature or nurture

3 Lifespan Theories

3.1 Psychosexual Theory of Development (Frued)

- The OG (for better or for worse); Sigmund Freud's theories on _____ behaviors and tendencies were among the first theories of child development

? Which historical perspective is Freud associated with?

- ☒ A) Evolutionary
- ☐ B) Biopsychology
- ☐ C) Psychoanalysis
- ☐ D) Cognitivism

Explanation:

- His focus was on the **psychosexual theory of development** which focused primarily on how stages and _____ towards certain erogenous zones and pleasure seeking in each one of those zones
 - These zones are: oral, anal, phallic, latency, and genital
 - Importantly, Freud placed *a lot* of emphasis on _____ as the time where development takes place, rather than throughout the lifespan
- In recent years, Freud's ideas have been less _____ validated than other theories
 - But the guy was right every once in awhile...

! Important

Even though Freud's exact stages and explanations have fallen out of favor, he was one of the earliest voices to point to the importance of childhood development in later life outcomes - without him, we may have not had the other theorists that come up in these next sections.

3.2 Psychosocial Theory of Development (Erikson)



- Erik Erikson was the primary theorist to develop [psychosocial theory of development](#), which focused less on the _____, and more on the social (duh)
 - More specifically, we pursue different types of social _____ in certain areas at several stages throughout our entire lifespan
 - Each stage of psychosocial development has a task or _____ between a negative and a positive outcome, which will have downstream effects on our development

Erikson's Psychosocial Stages of Development

Stage	Age (years)	Developmental Task	Description
1	0–1	Trust vs. mistrust	Trust (or mistrust) that basic needs, such as nourishment and affection, will be met
2	1–3	Autonomy vs. shame/doubt	Develop a sense of independence in many tasks
3	3–6	Initiative vs. guilt	Take initiative on some activities—may develop guilt when unsuccessful or boundaries overstepped
4	7–11	Industry vs. inferiority	Develop self-confidence in abilities when competent or sense of inferiority when not
5	12–18	Identity vs. confusion	Experiment with and develop identity and roles
6	19–29	Intimacy vs. isolation	Establish intimacy and relationships with others
7	30–64	Generativity vs. stagnation	Contribute to society and be part of a family
8	65–	Integrity vs. despair	Assess and make sense of life and meaning of contributions

 Discuss: Based on the brief descriptions of both, how are the psychosexual and psychosocial theories different and similar from one another?

 Important

One of the things that makes Erikson's theory unique is that it does put special emphasis on the entire lifespan, not just childhood

3.3 Cognitive Theory of Development (Piaget)



- Contrasting with the Psychosexual and Psychosocial, Jean Piaget formulated a developmental theory as being connected to distinct _____ stages, through the [cognitive theory of developments](#)
 - Piaget's theory of development was very strongly connected to the growing cognitive _____ of children as they matured.
- Piaget's ideas of cognitive development focused on how children produce _____ to help them categorize their world
 - Within these schemata, children [assimilate](#) _____ concepts into existing schemata
 - They also begin to [accommodate](#) _____ information

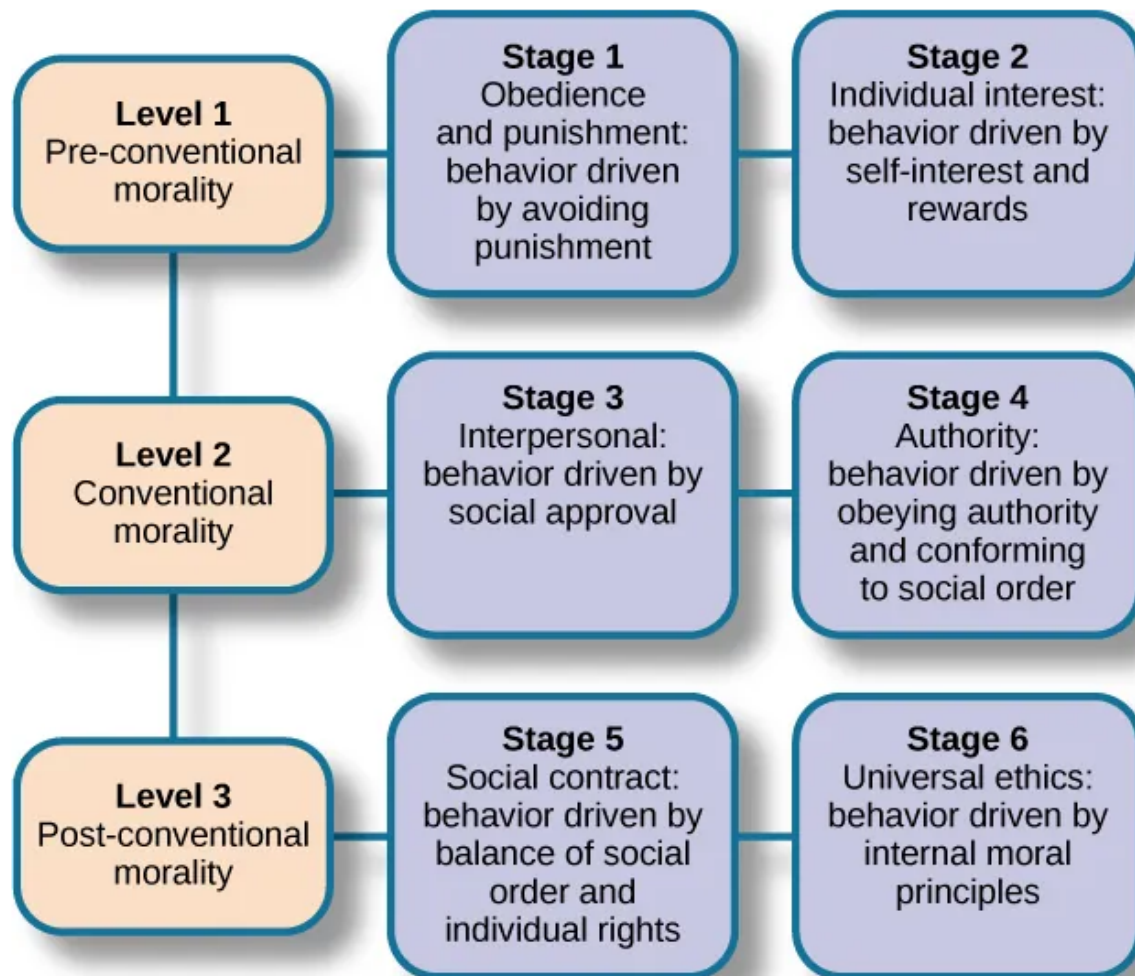
 Discuss: What is the difference between a schema and a concept?

Piaget's Stages of Cognitive Development

Age (years)	Stage	Description	Developmental issues
0–2	Sensorimotor	World experienced through senses and actions	Object permanence Stranger anxiety
2–6	Preoperational	Use words and images to represent things, but lack logical reasoning	Pretend play Egocentrism Language development
7–11	Concrete operational	Understand concrete events and analogies logically; perform arithmetical operations	Conservation Mathematical transformations
12–	Formal operational	Formal operations Utilize abstract reasoning	Abstract logic Moral reasoning

3.4 Moral Theory of Development (Kohlberg)

- Lawrence Kohlberg's [moral theory of developmental](#)



4 Conclusion

4.1 Recap

- Developmental psychology is not just about childhood, but about our entire lifespan. This includes how adulthood is influenced by our childhood, but also how we keep growing and evolving even once we are adults
- We can understand development sexually, socially, cognitive, and morally through the different theorists models of our growth and development - each of these models have their own stages related to different behaviors and goals

- Each model has its own set of unique vocabulary attached to it, try to pick up on what you could do to best support your learning of these terms (hint: remember that semantic encoding and elaborate rehearsal tend to be the most effective strategies!)
- Much like with how areas of psychology (e.g., perception) have disagreements in theory - we can look at development through several different lenses without necessarily determining one as fully “correct”

Key Terms

A

accommodate The process by which children modify, add, or change schemata to incorporate new and contradictory information [10](#)

assimilate The process by which children add congruent concepts into their already existing schemata [10](#)

C

cognitive development A person's internal, latent changes to their thinking, problem solving, memory, processing speed, etc. [3](#)

cognitive theory of development A developmental theory based upon distinct stages in cognitive abilities in children [10](#)

continuous development The view that development proceeds in a gradual, continuous, steadily increasing manner [5](#)

D

developmental milestones A specific, well-defined event/stage in a normative course of development [4](#)

developmental psychologist An empirical researcher who studies the physical, cognitive, and psychosocial change in a person over some period of time in their life [3](#)

discontinuous development The view that development has distinct stages with rapid change [5](#)

L

lifespan A person's whole course of life from conception and in utero, all the way to death [3](#)

M

moral theory of developmental A theory of development much more related to moral reasoning and increasing complexity of thought as one develops [11](#)

N

nature Our physical being, genetics, and biology - what we are born with [6](#)

normative approach A perspective / approach to developmental research that is concerned with charting the usual, typical, or normal healthy pattern of development [4](#)

nurture The environment and surrounding culture that plays a role in development [6](#)

P

physical development A persons' physiological and anatomical changes to the body and central nervous system [3](#)

psychosexual theory of development The developmental theory posited by Sigmund Freud, focused on stages and possible fixation on certain erogenous zones [7](#)

psychosocial development A persons' change to how they interact and socialize with others [3](#)

psychosocial theory of development A developmental theory focused on humans social interactions as a descriptor of developmental progress [8](#)